

Mantra Syllables of the Noble Laṅkāvatāra Sūtra

Āryalaṅkāvatārasūtradhāraṇī · Toh 589 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ལང་ཀར་གཤམ་པ་ལ་ཕག་འཆལ་ལོ།

Toh 589 in the Kangyur is a short dhāraṇī text associated with the Laṅkāvatāra Sūtra, known in Tibetan as Phags pa lang kar gshegs pa'i gzungs, and belonging to the broader class of dhāraṇī and mantra literature within the canon. The text presents a series of mantra syllables addressed to the bodhisattva Mahāmati, the principal interlocutor of the Laṅkāvatāra Sūtra, and promises powerful protection to any man or woman of noble lineage who holds, recites, or masters these syllables. It asserts that no deity, nāga, yakṣa, asura, garuḍa, or any other supernatural being will be able to find an opening or occasion to harm such a practitioner. Functioning as a protective spell closely linked to one of the great Mahāyāna sūtras, this brief text illustrates the important role that dhāraṇī formulas played in extending the spiritual and apotropaic power of canonical scripture into daily religious life.

Homage to the noble Laṅkāvatāra Sūtra. Mahāmati, these mantra syllables are to be declared. Thus:

Oṃ padme padme devai, hine hine hine, tsulu tsulu tsulu, hule hule hule, yule yule yule, pale pale pale, muṃ ccheda na de, bhinde bhañjva, mande pramade, dinakare svāhā.

Mahāmati, whatever son of noble lineage or daughter of noble lineage holds, retains, recites, or perfectly masters these mantra syllables — no opening or occasion will be found against them by any god or goddess, nāga or nāginī, yakṣa or yakṣiṇī, asura or asurī, garuḍa or garuḍiṇī, kinnara or kinnarī, great serpent or great serpent-female, gandharva or gandharvinī, spirit or spirit-female, kumbhāṇḍa or kumbhāṇḍiṇī, flesh-eater or flesh-eater-female, oppressor or oppressor-female, one who causes forgetfulness or female who causes forgetfulness, rākṣasa or rākṣasī, piśāca or piśācī, life-force thief, male or female, one who causes bodily decay, male or female — none among all these non-humans and the like whatsoever.

Whoever recites these mantra syllables will be counted as having recited the entirety of all the Laṅkāvatāra sūtras. These mantra syllables were proclaimed by the Blessed One for the purpose of repelling rākṣasas and the like.

The dhāraṇī mantra that constitutes the recitation of the entirety of all the noble Laṅkāvatāra sūtras is here complete.

Translator's Notes

- The list of spirit-beings in this passage follows a standard canonical enumeration. Several of the beings are beings of Indian mythological taxonomy rendered in Tibetan: garuḍa (nam mkha' lding), kinnara (mi'am ci), great nāga (lto 'phye chen po), gandharva (dri za), bhūta ('byung po), kumbhāṇḍa (grul bum), piśāca (sha za), and what are rendered here as "oppressor" (gnon po), "one who causes forgetfulness" (brjed byed), and "one who causes bodily decay" (lus srul po) are less standard epithets likely referring to specific classes of harmful spirits; the translations offered are based on the literal Tibetan. The term phramenpho / phramemo is identified here as piśāca on the basis of context and parallel lists, though the Tibetan term itself is somewhat opaque.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.